

The River Answers Back: A Better Question

河流的回应：更好的问题

Theme: 环境、自然与可持续发展 · New: 44 · Review: 18 · Planned cumulative progress: 44/6, 127

English Story

The better question came from a vegetable stall on the **west floor** of the market, over a cup of tea at the **fair**: who decided that the river is a drain and not a well? “The **difficulty** is not the water,” the trader said. “It is the **investment** in the **cement**.” A couple of us had come in from the land, and the air was full of **grain** dust.

The **map** on the wall showed a canal that had been transformed into a landing for boats, and a ditch that had become a booth for carrots and **pink** radishes. “A simple process is not the same as a natural one,” she said. “You can freeze a seed, but you cannot **freeze abundance**.”

The false assumption had a long leg and a low floor: the idea that a river is passive. “Hit the water with a stick and it waves back,” the boatman said. “The **cloud** above us, the **tooth** of the current, the **leak** in the bank: it is all one **brain**.”

The **whistle** of the midday train, the **bang** of a lift door, and the **crawl** of **mud** through the **canal**: the district needed a different question, not a bigger pump. “Ask what the water wants,” she said, “and the **temper** of the whole meeting changes.”

A feather, a dive into the channel, and a jar of ink in the **booth**: the small things had been measured and the big things had not. “**Inflation** is not a river problem,” Maya wrote, “and a button on a map is not a fact.”

The better question, in the end, was about the **polar** opposite of the old one: instead of asking how to remove water, ask where the **clay** and the **mud** want it to go. The **lavatory** at the back of the station, the **hip** of the embankment, and the water in the well all had to be re-measured. “A different map, not a better pump,” the director said. The star above the station, the bed of the channel, and the nature of the **nose** that could smell rain: all of it belonged to the same question.

中文翻译

更好的问题来自集市西侧地面上一个卖蔬菜的摊位，在展会上一杯茶的功夫里：是谁决定这条河是一条排水沟，而不是一口井？“困难不在水，”摊主说，“而在水泥上的投资。”我们中有两个人是从陆地上来的，空气里满是谷物的粉尘。

墙上的地图显示出一条已被改造成船只码头的运河，以及一条变成了胡萝卜和粉色萝卜摊棚的沟渠。“一个简单的过程不等于一个自然的过程，”她说，“你可以冷冻一颗种子，但你不能冷冻丰盛。”

那个错误的假设有一条长腿和一个低矮的地板：河流是被动的。“用棍子敲水，它会回你一道波浪，”船夫说，“我们头顶的云、水流的牙齿、岸边的渗漏：这都是同一个大脑。”

正午火车的汽笛、电梯门的一声巨响，以及泥浆在水渠里的爬行：这个地区需要的是一个不同的问题，而不是一台更大的水泵。“问问水想要什么，”她说，“整场会议的脾气就变了。”

一根羽毛、一次跃入河道，以及摊棚里一瓶墨水：小事被测量了，而大事没有。“通货膨胀不是河流问题，”曼雅写道，“而地图上的一个按钮不是事实。”

说到底，那个更好的问题与旧问题正好是两极相反：与其问怎样把水排掉，不如问黏土和泥想要它去哪里。站后的厕所、堤岸的臀部，以及井里的水，都必须重新测量。“换一张地图，不是换一台更好的泵，”主管说。站上方的星星、河道的床，以及那个能闻出雨来的鼻子的本性：所有这一切都属于同一个问题。

Core Vocabulary · 核心词汇

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
floor flo: POS: n	n. 地板, 楼层, 底部, 底价; vt. 铺地板, 打倒; n. 地面, 地板, 基底; [计] 基底 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the inside lower horizontal surface (as of a room, hallway, tent, or other structure); n. a structure consi...
west west POS: n	n. 西方, 西部; a. 西方的, 向西的; adv. 向西, 自西方, 在西方 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the countries of (originally) Europe and (now including) North America and South America; n. the cardinal c...
difficulty 'difikəlti POS: n	n. 困难, 难点 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a factor causing trouble in achieving a positive result or tending to produce a negative result; n. a condi...
investment in'vestmənt POS: n	n. 投资; [医] 包埋料, 围模料, 包埋法, 围模法 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. money that is invested with an expectation of profit; n. the commitment of something other than money (time)...
leg leg POS: n	n. 腿, 假腿, 路程; vi. 走, 跑 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a human limb; commonly used to refer to a whole limb but technically only the part of the limb between the...
tea ti: POS: n	n. 茶, 茶叶; [医] 茶, 茶剂, 浸剂 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a beverage made by steeping tea leaves in water; n. a light midafternoon meal of tea and sandwiches or cake...
fair feə POS: n	n. 展览会, 市集, 美好的事物; a. 公平的, 按规则进行的, 不好不坏的, 晴朗的, 美丽的; adv. 公平地, 正面地, 有教养地... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. gathering of producers to promote business; n. a competitive exhibition of farm products; v. join so that th...
brain brein POS: n	n. 脑; vt. 打碎脑部 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. that part of the central nervous system that includes all the higher nervous centers; enclosed within the...
stick stik POS: n	n. 棍, 棒, 刺, 枯枝, 茎, 条状物; vt. 插进, 刺入, 钉住, 伸出, 粘贴, 停止; vi. 粘住, 停留, 坚持, 陷住, ... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an implement consisting of a length of wood; n. a small thin branch of a tree; n. a lever used by a pilot to...
lift lift POS: n	n. 举起, 帮助, 昂扬, 电梯; vt. 升高, 提高, 鼓舞, 清偿, 空运, 举起, 剽窃; vi. 升起, 消散, 耸立 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the act of giving temporary assistance; n. a wave that lifts the surface of the water or ground; n. a device...
wave weiv POS: n	n. 波, 波浪, 波动, 起伏, 高潮, 潮涌, 挥手致意, (气压)突变; vi. 波动, 飘动, 挥手示意, 起伏; vt. 使波动, ... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. one of a series of ridges that moves across the surface of a liquid (especially across a large body of wat...
map mæp POS: n	n. 地图, 天体图, 映像; vt. 映射, 绘制...地图, 计划; [计] 实用程序, 映射, 制造自动化协议 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a diagrammatic representation of the earth's surface (or part of it); v. make a map of; show or establish t...
nose nəuz POS: n	n. 鼻子, 突出部分, 嗅觉; vt. 嗅到, 探出, 用鼻子触; vi. 闻, 嗅, 探听, 告密 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the organ of smell and entrance to the respiratory tract; the prominent part of the face of man or other m...
tooth tu:θ POS: n	n. 牙齿, 齿状物, 爱好; vt. 装以齿, 将...切成齿状; vi. 啮合 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. hard bone-like structures in the jaws of vertebrates; used for biting and chewing or for attack and defense...
cloud klaud POS: n	n. 云, 阴暗, 烟雾, 疑团; vt. 以云遮蔽, 笼罩, 使黯然; vi. 乌云密布, 阴沉 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any collection of particles (e.g., smoke or dust) or gases that is visible; n. a visible mass of water or i...
seed si:d POS: n	n. 种子, 籽, 萌芽, 子孙, 精液; vt. 在...播种, 催...发育, 脱...籽; vi. 结实, 播种 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a small hard fruit; n. a mature fertilized plant ovule consisting of an embryo and its food source and havi...
vegetable 'vedʒəteɪbl POS: n	n. 蔬菜, 植物, 无精打采之人; a. 蔬菜的, 植物的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. edible seeds or roots or stems or leaves or bulbs or tubers or nonsweet fruits of any of numerous herbaceo...
inflation in'fleɪʃən POS: n	n. 胀大, 夸张, 通货膨胀; [化] 充气吹胀; 膨胀 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a general and progressive increase in prices; n. (cosmology) a brief exponential expansion of the universe...
transform træns'fɔ:m POS: vt	vt. 使转换, 改变, 改造, 使...变形; vi. 改变, 转化, 变换; [计] 变换 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. subject to a mathematical transformation; v. change or alter in form, appearance, or nature; v. change in ou...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
pink pɪŋk POS: n	n. 粉红色, 石竹花, 化身, 典范, 头面人物, 极度; a. 粉红的, 石竹科的, 比较激进的, 脸色发红的, 精致的, 有点下流的; ... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a light shade of red; n. any of various flowers of plants of the genus <i>Dianthus</i> cultivated for their fragra...
hip hɪp POS: n	n. 臀部, 蔷薇果, 忧郁; a. 熟悉内情的; vt. 使忧郁, 给(屋顶)造屋脊; interj. 喝彩声 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. either side of the body below the waist and above the thigh; n. the ball-and-socket joint between the head...
button ˈbʌtən POS: n	n. 钮扣, 按钮; vi. 扣住; vt. 钉钮扣于, 扣紧; [计] 按钮 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a round fastener sewn to shirts and coats etc to fit through buttonholes; n. any of various plant parts tha...
freeze friːz POS: vi	vi. 冻结, 冷冻, 僵硬, 楞住; vt. 使结冰, 使冻住, 使呆住; n. 结冰, 凝固; [计] 冻结 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the withdrawal of heat to change something from a liquid to a solid; n. weather cold enough to cause freezi...
canal kəˈnæl POS: n	n. 运河, 水道, 管, 沟渠; vt. 开运河 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. (astronomy) an indistinct surface feature of Mars once thought to be a system of channels; they are now be...
grain greɪn POS: n	n. 谷粒, 颗粒, 谷类, 纹理, 本质; v. (使)成谷粒 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a relatively small granular particle of a substance; n. foodstuff prepared from the starchy grains of cerea...
mud mʌd POS: n	n. 泥, 诽谤; vt. 弄脏 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. water soaked soil; soft wet earth; n. slanderous remarks or charges; v. plaster with mud
landing ˈlændɪŋ POS: n	n. 登陆, 码头, 降落; [经] 上岸, 登陆, 降落 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an intermediate platform in a staircase; n. structure providing a place where boats can land people or good...
drain dreɪn POS: n	n. 排水沟, 消耗, 排水; vt. 排出, 喝光, 耗尽; vi. 排水, 流干 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. emptying something accomplished by allowing liquid to run out of it; n. tube inserted into a body cavity (a...
crawl krəʊl POS: n	n. 爬行, 匍匐而行, 养鱼池; v. 爬行 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a very slow movement; n. a swimming stroke; arms are moved alternately overhead accompanied by a flutter ki...
clay kleɪ POS: n	n. 泥土, 肉体, 黏土; [化] 粘土 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a very fine-grained soil that is plastic when moist but hard when fired; n. United States general who comma...
booth buːθ POS: n	n. 亭, 摊棚; [经] 货摊, 电话间 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a table (in a restaurant or bar) surrounded by two high-backed benches; n. small area set off by walls for...
feather ˈfeðə POS: n	n. 羽毛; vi. 长羽毛; vt. 用羽毛装饰 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the light horny waterproof structure forming the external covering of birds; n. turning an oar parallel to...
bang bæŋ POS: n	n. 重击, 突然巨响, 刘海; v. 发巨响, 重击; adv. 砰然地, 突然巨响地, 直接地; [计] 撞击符 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a sudden very loud noise; n. a border of hair that is cut short and hangs across the forehead; n. the swift...
carrot ˈkærət POS: n	n. 胡萝卜; [医] 胡萝卜 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. deep orange edible root of the cultivated carrot plant; n. perennial plant widely cultivated as an annual i...
temper ˈtempə POS: n	n. (钢等的)硬度, 脾气, 心情, 中和剂, 倾向, 回火; vt. 使回火, 锻炼, 调和, 使缓和; vi. 回火 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a characteristic (habitual or relatively temporary) state of feeling; n. a disposition to exhibit uncontrol...
dive daɪv POS: n	n. 潜水, 跳水; vi. 跳水, 俯冲, 猛冲; vt. 把...突然伸入 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a headlong plunge into water; n. a steep nose-down descent by an aircraft; v. drop steeply; v. plunge into wa...
leak li:k POS: n	n. 漏洞, 漏处, 漏出, 泄漏; vi. 漏, 泄漏; vt. 使渗漏 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an accidental hole that allows something (fluid or light etc.) to enter or escape; n. soft watery rot in fr...
ink ɪŋk POS: n	n. 墨水, 墨汁; vt. 涂墨水于, 签署, 加墨水 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a liquid used for printing or writing or drawing; n. dark protective fluid ejected into the water by cuttle...
abundance əˈbʌndəns POS: n	n. 丰富, 充足, 大量; [经] 丰富, 充裕 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the property of a more than adequate quantity or supply; n. (physics) the ratio of the number of atoms of a...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
cement si'ment POS: n	n. 水泥, 胶结剂; vt. 胶合, 用水泥涂; vi. 黏牢 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. concrete pavement is sometimes referred to as cement; n. a building material that is a powder made of a mix...
ditch ditʃ POS: n	n. 沟渠; vt. 在...开沟; vi. 开沟 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a long narrow excavation in the earth; n. any small natural waterway; v. forsake; v. make an emergency landin...
whistle 'hwisl POS: n	n. 口哨, 汽笛, 呼啸声, 口哨声; vi. 吹口哨, 鸣汽笛, 发嘘声; vt. 用口哨或吹哨传意, 用口哨演奏 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the sound made by something moving rapidly or by steam coming out of a small aperture; n. the act of signal...
polar 'pəʊlə POS: a	a. 两极的, 极地的, 正好相反的, 极性的; n. 极线, 极面 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. having a pair of equal and opposite charges; a. located at or near or coming from the earth's poles; a. of o...
lavatory 'lævətəri POS: n	n. 洗脸盆, 厕所 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n a room or building equipped with one or more toilets; n a bathroom sink that is permanently installed and co...